

IN PROFILE

Paul Wittgenstein

Ravel was one of several composers who was commissioned by Paul Wittgenstein (the older brother of philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein), a concert pianist who had lost his right arm in World War I. Ravel responded with the Piano Concerto for the Left Hand in D major, composed in 1929–1930, at the same time as he was working on his Piano Concerto in G.

Wittgenstein was initially unhappy with the jazz-inspired piece, and Ravel was infuriated by his early interpretation of it, but in time the pianist grew to understand and appreciate Ravel's intentions and premiered the work in 1932.



PAUL
WITTGENSTEIN